In an India Today conclave session that doubled as theatre and time capsule, seven editors who shaped the magazine over its 50-year arc gathered to recreate the magazine's fabled editorial meeting with the news of March 2026 as their weekly brief. What followed was less a panel discussion than a masterclass in the alchemy of newsmagazine journalism: how to distil a week's chaos into a single arresting cover.

The setting was the West Asia war, now entering a phase that had begun pinching Indian households through rising oil and gas prices. Aroon Purie, the founder of the magazine who has presided over more than 2,000 cover decisions, laid down the grammar he has applied since 1975: Why now? Who cares? What next? A story, he insisted, must travel beyond the radius of South Block; it must matter to people who will never attend an editorial meeting.

The Print founder-editor Shekhar Gupta stressed the importance of reporting from the ground, insisting that credible journalism cannot be done from afar. Sending correspondents into conflict zones had historically given INDIA TODAY an edge over competitors.

The New Indian Express editorial director Prabhu

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**



SHEKHAR GUPTA
Founder Editor, The Print

SWAPAN DASGUPTA
Member, BJP National Executive

Competition inside the newsroom was intense, but assignments were never about favourites. If a reporter had the track record and the story, he or she got the chance to go out and report it
—Raj Chengappa

Everybody tells you what happened and we must tell why it happened and what is next. That was what made INDIA TODAY cutting edge
—Prabhu Chawla

Every story has to pass three tests: why now, who cares, and what next. Our job is to ask whether the story travels beyond the Lutyens' circle and matters to readers across the country
—AROON PURIE

Sometimes when reality overwhelms readers, culture and cinema offer another way to understand the moment. A film can reflect the politics of its time just as powerfully...
—Kaveree Bamzai

In the 1980s, we didn't worry about what politicians thought. If the Nellie massacre deserved the cover, we put it there. That independence was central to IT's credibility
—T.N. Ninan

In the 1980s, all the ministries, the PMOs, they all used to leak like a sieve. You could get almost anything you wanted. When was the last time you got a leak from this PMO?
—Swapan Dasgupta

Editorial meetings could be brutal. Ideas were shot down without mercy, but the arguments were never about ideology. They were always about news value
—Shekhar Gupta